A SHORT GUIDE FOR FIRST-TIME BUYERS

Your first home in England

Seven simple steps to help you plan your purchase, ask the right questions and understand when you are committed.



01 Set a comfortable budget

Work out your deposit, affordable monthly mortgage payment and household bills. Keep money aside for fees, repairs and emergencies. A 5%-10% deposit may be enough for some mortgages; eligibility and affordability still apply. [2]

02 Prepare for a mortgage

Speak to a regulated mortgage adviser or lender. Gather ID, bank statements, income records and deposit evidence. An **agreement in principle (AIP)** indicates possible borrowing; it is not a guaranteed mortgage offer. [1-2]

03 View homes and make an offer

Check location, condition and ongoing charges. For a leasehold home, ask about the lease length, service charges and planned major works. Make your offer through the agent, normally **subject to contract**. An accepted offer is usually not legally binding. [1, 3]

> **Start here**
> Choose your maximum monthly housing budget, confirm your available deposit and arrange a mortgage affordability discussion.

CHECKS, CONTRACTS AND COMPLETION

From an accepted offer to the keys

The mortgage, survey and legal work often run alongside each other. Keep in touch with your adviser, solicitor and estate agent.

04 Instruct your solicitor and apply for the mortgage

Choose a solicitor or licensed conveyancer on your lender's panel. Confirm the full quote, provide ID and source-of-funds evidence, then submit your mortgage application. The lender will assess you and value the property. [1, 3]

05 Check the property and the legal position

Arrange a suitable independent survey; the lender's valuation is not a condition survey. Your lawyer checks ownership, searches, the contract and any lease. Discuss defects, repair quotes and unresolved enquiries before deciding to proceed. [1, 4]

06 Exchange contracts

Your solicitor confirms the checks, finance and cleared funds are ready. Agree the completion date, contract deposit and insurance start date. Exchange normally makes the purchase legally binding; pulling out afterwards can have serious financial consequences. [5]

07 Complete and move in

Your solicitor transfers the remaining purchase money. Once completion is confirmed, collect the keys, take meter readings and update utilities and Council Tax. Your solicitor handles the SDLT return where needed and registration of your ownership. [1, 5]

> **One deposit, not two**
> The contract deposit paid at exchange forms part of your contribution to the price. It is often 10%, but can be negotiated. If your deposit is 5%, ask your solicitor to agree the arrangements and explain any remaining liability. [5]

Five terms you will hear

Conveyancing: the legal transfer of the home. **Searches:** checks for issues affecting it. **Chain:** linked sales that depend on each other. **Exchange:** the binding contract stage. **Completion:** when payment finishes the purchase. [1, 3, 5]

QUICK BUDGET AND CHECKLIST

Budget and next steps

Get written quotes. These are broad planning allowances, not fixed prices; the property and your circumstances can change them. [6]

COST	WHAT TO ALLOW FOR
Deposit	For illustration: 5% of £250,000 = £12,500; 10% = £25,000. The lender confirms what is needed.
Legal work and searches	About £2,000 legal fees including VAT, plus roughly £250-£300 for searches. Check registration, transfer and other extra fees.
Survey	Roughly £400-£1,500, depending on the home and survey level.
Mortgage and adviser fees	Some products have no product fee; others charge £1,000-£2,000+. Ask separately about adviser and valuation fees.
Moving and setup	Removals can start around £400 and exceed £1,000. Add insurance, repairs, furnishings and any overlapping rent.
Stamp Duty Land Tax (SDLT)	Relief may apply to qualifying first-time buyers. Ask your solicitor to confirm the current HMRC rules and exact bill. [7]

How long should you plan for?
Allow roughly **8-16 weeks from an accepted offer to completion** as a Kestrel planning estimate, not a promise. Saving and searching take additional time. Chains, lease issues and missing documents can extend the process.

Before exchange, confirm all four

Your mortgage offer is valid. Your survey and legal questions are resolved. Your full cash requirement is covered. Your completion date and insurance arrangements are agreed. [5]

Useful links - checked 22 October 2026

[1] GOV.UK: buying process
[2] MoneyHelper: first-time buyer basics
[3] MoneyHelper: buying stages
[4] RICS: choosing a home survey
[5] MoneyHelper: exchange and completion
[6] MoneyHelper: buying and moving costs
[7] HMRC: SDLT reliefs and exemptions

For an ordinary home purchase in England to live in. Auctions, shared ownership and unusual purchases need extra advice. Check live scheme and tax rules. Illustration: AI-generated.